Please check the examination details below before entering your candidate information

Candidate surname | Other names

Centre Number | Candidate Number

# Pearson Edexcel GCSE (9-1)

## Thursday 4 June 2026

Morning (Time: 1 hour 50 minutes - total time for **both** booklets)

# History

**BOOKLET B4: Early Elizabethan England, 1558-88**

Paper reference

**1HI0/B4 (Paper 2)**

**You must have:**
The corresponding booklet P.

Total Marks

## Instructions

- Use **black** ink or ball-point pen.
- **Fill in the boxes** at the top of this page with your name, centre number and candidate number.
- There are two booklets in this question paper. **This is booklet B.**
- Answer questions 1(a), 1(b), 2 and **either 3 or 4** in this booklet.
- Check you have the corresponding booklet P.
- Answer the questions in the spaces provided
  *- there may be more space than you need.*

## Information

- The total mark for this booklet is 32.
- The total time for **both** booklets is 1 hour 50 minutes.
- The marks for **each** question are shown in brackets
  *- use this as a guide as to how much time to spend on each question.*
- **Do not forget to complete booklet P.**

## Advice

- Read each question carefully before you start to answer it.

- Try to divide your time equally between each booklet of the question paper.
- Check your answers if you have time at the end.

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**Early Elizabethan England, 1558-88**

**Answer Question 1(a), Question 1(b), Question 2 and EITHER Question 3 OR Question 4.**

**1** (a) Describe one feature of the role of the Church of England in early Elizabethan society. (2)

**Teacher Mark Scheme Model Answer:**
One key feature was the enforcement of Elizabeth's religious laws and social control. For example, churchwardens and bishops conducted official "visitations" to inspect parishes, ensuring that all clergy took the oath of loyalty to the Queen and that the Protestant Book of Common Prayer was being strictly used.

(b) Describe one feature of Walsingham and the use of spies. (2)

**Teacher Mark Scheme Model Answer:**
One feature was the interception and decoding of secret correspondence. Walsingham employed a specialist codebreaker named Thomas Phelippes to decipher letters sent by conspirators, which allowed the spy network to catch Mary, Queen of Scots, sending coded letters inside beer barrels to Anthony Babington in 1586.

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**(Total for Question 1 = 4 marks)**

**2** **Explain why Elizabeth's religious settlement was introduced in 1559.** (12)

*You **may** use the following in your answer:*

- religious divisions
- the French threat

*You **must** also use information of your own.*

**Teacher Mark Scheme Model Answer:**

Elizabeth introduced her religious settlement in 1559 primarily to heal the intense **religious divisions** that had fractured England. Following the reigns of Edward VI, who established a strict Protestant church, and Mary I, who violently restored Catholicism by burning almost 300 Protestants, England was deeply split. The north remained heavily Catholic, while London and the south-east were increasingly Protestant. Elizabeth recognised that a failure to find a compromise would likely spark a religious civil war. Consequently, she designed her "Middle Way" to pacify both sides: she kept traditional Catholic elements, such as highly decorated vestments and crucifixes to appease the Catholics, while introducing a Protestant Book of Common Prayer in English to satisfy Protestants. This compromise was essential to secure domestic peace.

Secondly, Elizabeth was forced to introduce the religious settlement due to the immediate geopolitical **French threat**. At her accession in 1558, England was at war with France, and the French had strong influence in Scotland through the 'Auld Alliance'. Mary, Queen of Scots—a devout Catholic with a strong claim to the English throne—was married to the heir to the French throne. If Elizabeth had established a radical, aggressive Protestant church immediately, she risked provoking a joint invasion from Catholic France and Scotland. By establishing a compromise settlement and designating herself "Supreme Governor" rather than "Supreme Head" of the Church (appeasing the Pope and Catholic monarchs by not claiming spiritual headship), Elizabeth minimised the threat of foreign intervention while England was financially weak and militarily vulnerable.

Finally, the settlement was introduced to firmly establish **Elizabeth's personal royal authority** and reclaim control from Rome, a factor she achieved through her own political calculations. Under Mary I, the Pope's authority over the English Church had been restored. Elizabeth needed to reclaim the crown's power over religious matters and secure the loyalty of the clergy. The Act of Supremacy (1559) forced all public officials and clergy to swear an oath of loyalty to Elizabeth. This was a vital political tool because the Church of England was a massive engine of state power: priests delivered the Queen's messages to the illiterate population every Sunday, ensuring

social control and maintaining the 'Great Chain of Being'. The settlement was therefore introduced as much for political survival as it was for religious peace.

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**(Total for Question 2 = 12 marks)**

**Answer EITHER Question 3 OR Question 4.**

**EITHER**

**3** **'Walsingham and the use of spies was the main reason for the significance of Mary Queen of Scots' execution in 1587.'**

**How far do you agree? Explain your answer.**

*You **may** use the following in your answer:*

- the Babington Plot
- the Catholic challenge

*You **must** also use information of your own.*

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**(Total for Question 3 = 16 marks)**

**OR**

**4** **'The drive to expand trade was the main reason for the attempted colonisation of Virginia.'**

**How far do you agree? Explain your answer.**

*You **may** use the following in your answer:*

- new technology
- the significance of Raleigh

*You **must** also use information of your own.*

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**(Total for Question 4 = 16 marks)**

Indicate which question you are answering by marking a cross in the box ☒. If you change your mind, put a line through the box ☒ and then indicate your new question with a cross ☒.

Chosen question number: Question 3 ☐ Question 4 ☐

**Teacher Mark Scheme (Question 3):**

**Sir Francis Walsingham's** intelligence network was undoubtedly a highly significant factor in bringing about the execution of Mary, Queen of Scots, but it was not the sole reason. While Walsingham provided the concrete legal proof of treason needed to justify executing an anointed monarch, the execution was ultimately caused by Mary's continuous, existential threat to Elizabeth's throne, which was driven by her strong dynastic claim and the broader international Catholic threat.

On the one hand, Walsingham's espionage was the immediate trigger for the execution because it successfully exposed **the Babington Plot** of 1586. Mary had been kept under house arrest in England for 18 years, during which Elizabeth had repeatedly refused to execute her due to her belief in the Divine Right of Kings. However, Walsingham used a double agent, Gilbert Gifford, to set up a secure letter-routing system using beer barrels. This was a trap; every letter sent between Anthony Babington and Mary Stuart was intercepted, copied, and decoded by Walsingham's cryptographer, Thomas Phelippes. When Mary wrote a letter explicitly approving the assassination of Elizabeth, Walsingham had the irrefutable evidence he needed. This letter provided the legal justification that forced Elizabeth's Privy Council to demand Mary's trial and subsequent execution in February 1587.

On the other hand, the wider **Catholic challenge** was a more fundamental, long-term cause of Mary's execution. As long as Mary lived, she was a constant figurehead for Catholic rebellion. Since the Pope had excommunicated Elizabeth in 1570, English Catholics were released from their allegiance to her, making any plot to replace Elizabeth with Mary a holy duty. Mary was directly involved in, or the inspiration for, the Revolt of the Northern Earls (1569), the Ridolfi Plot (1571), and the Throckmorton Plot (1583). The northern nobility, led by the Earls of Northumberland and Westmorland, rose in rebellion specifically to restore Catholicism and put Mary on the throne. It was this relentless, existential danger to the Protestant state—not just the spies' discovery of the letters—that convinced Elizabeth's ministers that "as long as there is life in her, there is hope in them."

Furthermore, the execution was driven by the changing political attitudes of Elizabeth's **Privy Council and Parliament**, who actively worked to force Elizabeth's hand. Following the Throckmorton Plot and the assassination of the Dutch Protestant leader William of Orange in 1584, Elizabeth's advisors were terrified that she would be murdered next, leaving England to descend into Catholic chaos. To counter this, they drafted the Bond of Association (1584), which stated that if Elizabeth were assassinated, anyone who benefited from her death (i.e., Mary) would be executed. Parliament repeatedly petitioned Elizabeth to sign Mary's death warrant, viewing her

continued survival as a betrayal of her Protestant subjects. When the Babington Plot confirmed Mary's treason, the Privy Council immediately pushed the death warrant through, even sending it to be carried out behind Elizabeth's back once she had signed it.

In conclusion, I partially agree with the statement. Walsingham's use of spies was the decisive *catalyst* for the execution because his decryption of the Babington correspondence provided the absolute legal proof required to overcome Elizabeth's dynastic hesitation. However, the *primary* reason Mary was executed was her status as a permanent, living Catholic claimant. Had Mary not possessed a legitimate claim to the Tudor crown and the backing of Catholic Europe, the plots would not have had any chance of success, and her execution would not have been politically necessary.

**Teacher Mark Scheme (Question 4):**

The attempted colonisation of Virginia in 1585 was driven by a complex mixture of economic, strategic, and political factors. While the **drive to expand trade** and break Spain's commercial monopoly was a major economic motive, the strategic desire to establish a military outpost to attack Spain, combined with the personal ambition and organisation of **Sir Walter Raleigh**, were more critical in transforming these plans into an actual expedition.

On the one hand, the drive to expand trade was a highly significant cause of the colonisation attempt. Historically, England's economy relied heavily on exporting woollen cloth to Europe through the port of Antwerp. However, when Spain crushed the Dutch Revolt, Antwerp was closed to English merchants, causing a major economic crisis. English merchants desperately needed to find new markets and raw materials. Virginia was believed to be rich in valuable resources, including timber, fur, and tobacco. By colonising North America, England hoped to establish self-sufficiency, import luxury goods directly without paying high Spanish taxes, and find new consumer markets for English wool, thereby reviving the nation's wealth.

On the other hand, the strategic, military motivation of creating a naval base against Spain was arguably more pressing. By 1585, England and Spain were on the brink of war. Elizabeth and her advisors knew that England could not match Spain's massive army, so they aimed to weaken Spain financially by attacking its silver-carrying treasure fleets sailing from the Americas. Virginia was located in a perfect strategic position: far enough north to be safe from Spanish bases in Florida, but close enough to the Caribbean to allow English privateers, such as Sir Francis Drake, to raid Spanish ships and then retreat safely to a secure English port to unload their stolen riches.

Furthermore, the colonisation attempt would never have occurred without **the significance of Raleigh**. Raleigh was a wealthy courtier who was granted a royal patent by Queen Elizabeth in 1584 to explore and colonise "heathen lands". Raleigh acted as the essential organiser: he raised the vast sums of money needed by promoting the colony to investors, oversaw the building and outfitting of the ships, and carefully selected the colonists, including the mathematician Thomas Harriot to navigate and map the territory. Although Elizabeth refused to let Raleigh sail himself because she could not risk losing her favourite courtier, his political influence and financial backing were the engines behind the entire enterprise.

Finally, the colonisation attempt was made possible by **new technology**. During Elizabeth's reign, ship design had progressed significantly: the development of the "galleon" provided English sailors with larger, faster, and more stable ships capable of

surviving the treacherous Atlantic crossing while carrying heavy cannons and extensive supplies. This was supported by navigational advancements, including the widespread use of the magnetic compass, the astrolabe, and the quadrant, which allowed navigators to accurately calculate their latitude at sea. Without these technical breakthroughs, Raleigh's plans would have remained a physical impossibility.

In conclusion, I partially agree with the statement. The drive to expand trade provided the initial economic justification for the expedition, particularly after the collapse of the Antwerp cloth trade. However, the strategic need to establish a military naval base to disrupt Spanish shipping as war loomed was the primary geopolitical motivator. Raleigh's unique ability to secure investment and royal support was the practical mechanism that turned this strategic dream into reality.

**TOTAL FOR BOOKLET B = 32 MARKS**

**PLEASE ENSURE YOU ALSO COMPLETE BOOKLET P.**

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